# AI makes us faster. Who keeps us coherent?

Governance, systems, and the new role of DesignOps in product teams




- More possibility.
- More responsibility.

# The production floor is everywhere.

## Product

PM + AI

- Brief
- Requirements
- Hypotheses

## Research

RESEARCH + AI

- Synthesis
- Insights
- Questions

## Design

DESIGN + AI

- Concepts
- Prototypes
- Patterns

## Engineering

ENGINEERING + AI

- Components
- Code
- Tests

The bottleneck moves: **production → alignment → quality.**

# Julian Alvarado

## Xbox Design Ops

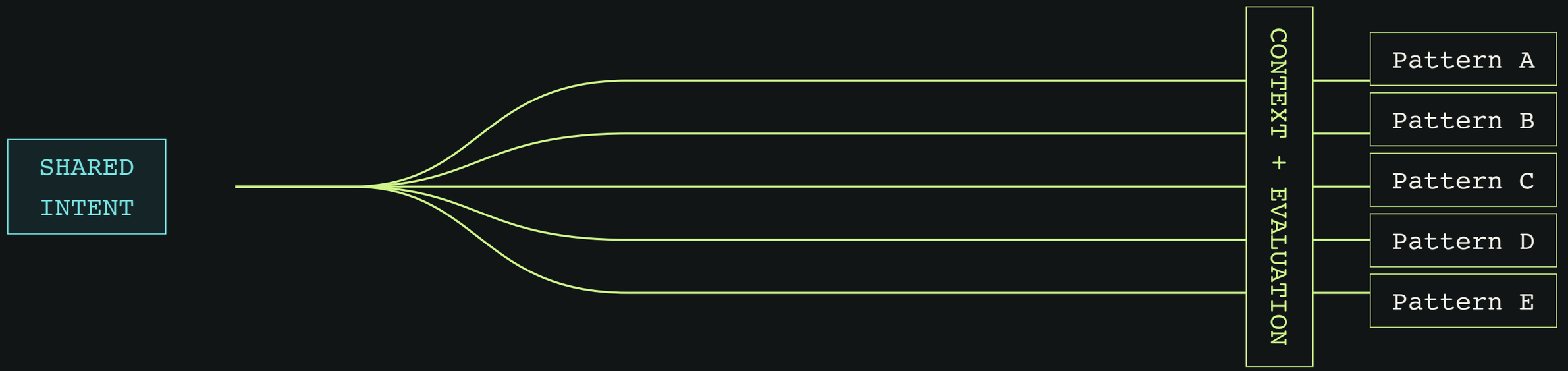
Julian Alvarado is a Senior Program Manager and Design Operations leader at Microsoft, helping Xbox Design scale through better systems, clearer processes, and responsible AI.

He works across teams and studios to improve how designers plan, learn, and deliver—building resilient, people-centered creative organizations.

Outside work, Julian is a daily CrossFit devotee and a “forever blue belt” in jiu-jitsu. A retired musician, he still loves live shows and enjoys drawing at home. Currently in rotation: Radiohead, Lenny Kravitz, Oasis, and Crosses.

# AI doesn't just accelerate work. It accelerates variation.

More AI → More output → More variation → More decisions → More inconsistency




Distinct ideas. Shared constraints. Accountable decisions.

# Three questions.
# One coherent system.

## GOVERN

Who can accept the choice?

## CONTEXT

What must the choice respect?

## EVALUATE

What makes it acceptable?

# Fix the form. Keep the lesson.

STEP 6 OF 6

## Check the next result

### Can the next person start alone?

The next proposed form

Workspace name first. Invitations optional.

The review

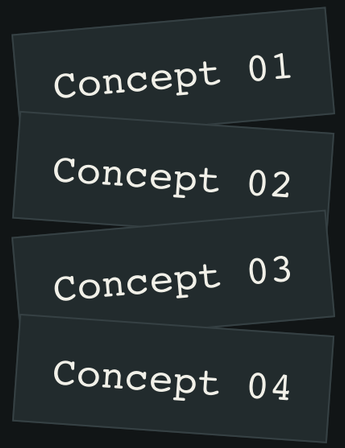
Setup works without a teammate email.

Still to check

Accessibility and whether it works for real users.

This requirement is met. The review is not over.

# Many possible outputs.
# One accountable judgment.




Possibility is abundant.

**SHARED QUALITY RUBRIC**

- ☐ System compliance
- ☐ User needs
- ☐ Accessibility
- ☐ Brand
- ☐ Product strategy
- ☐ Engineering feasibility

Evidence + checks + expert critique

## Human decision

Accept, revise,
or reject—with reasons.

OWNERSHIP STAYS HUMAN

Automated checks inform judgment. **They do not prove a design is good.**

# Don't just save the output. Capture the learning.

Keep the decision and its reason.
Share them with the next team.

1. AI proposes a design — using shared guidance
2. The team reviews it — against the user's need
3. Save the lesson — decision + reason + owner
4. Update the guidance — for the next team + AI
5. Check the next result — do not assume success

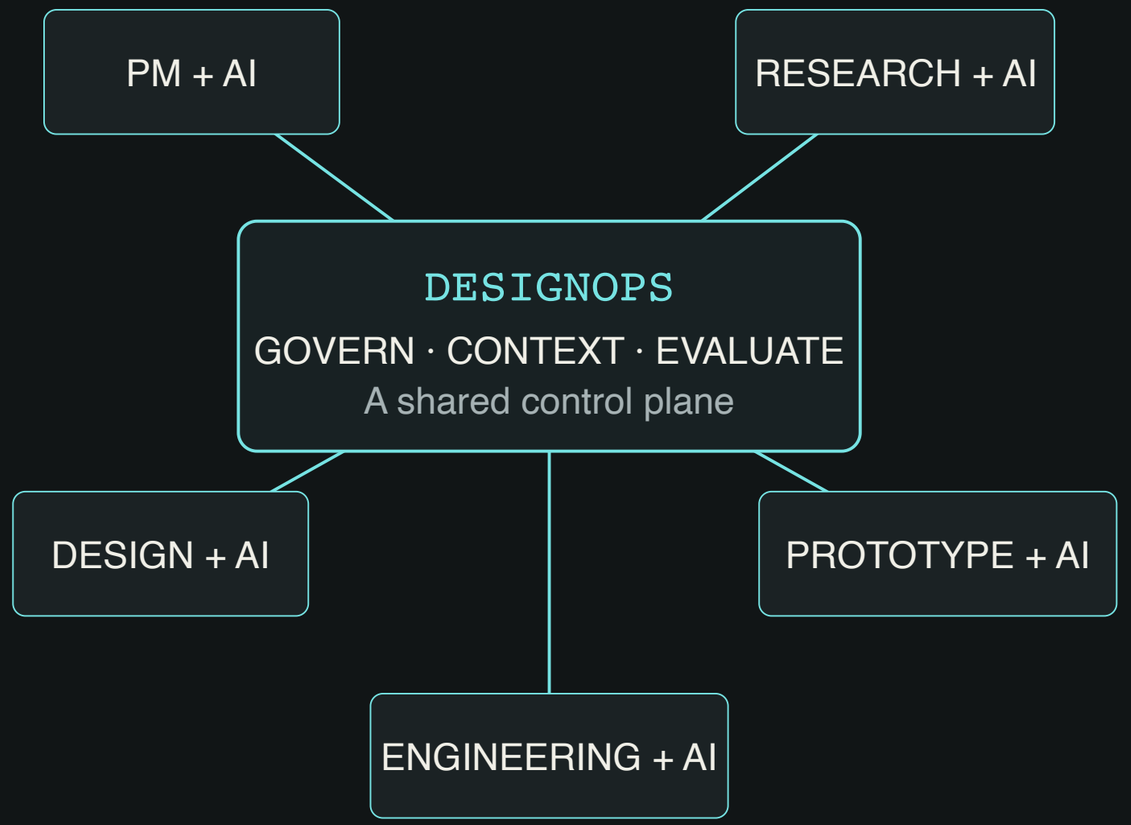
# Same foundations.
# A larger operating system.

PEOPLE
PROCESS
SYSTEMS

| TRADITIONAL FOCUS | EXPANDED AI-ERA SCOPE |
| --- | --- |
| Optimize workflows | Architect human–AI workflows |
| Document processes | Encode organizational knowledge |
| Scale design systems | Make systems AI-readable |
| Enable designers | Enable product teams |
| Measure efficiency | Measure quality + outcomes |
| Facilitate consistency | Govern generated variation |

# Not doing all the work. Connecting the system.

DesignOps defines the conditions under which the work happens.




Domain experts still own product decisions.

# Less waiting.
# More learning, together.

**Sequential handoffs**

SIMPLIFIED BEFORE

Research → Brief → Mocks → Build → Release

Customer need → handoff → wait → handoff → wait → customer feedback

**Shared intent. Joint execution.**

PROPOSED PILOT

Mission · Milestones · Metrics → Spec ↔ concept ↔ HTML/CSS → Experiment ↔ learn

Customer need → PM + research + design + engineering → customer feedback

Measure production time, review effort, and learning cadence.

Hypothesis: production can shrink; experimentation can expand. Validate it.

# Your next infrastructure is already in your documentation.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Guidelines | → | Machine-readable rules |
| Design system | → | AI-readable design system |
| Documentation | → | Reusable context packages |
| Critique | → | Evaluation rubrics |

SHARED GUIDANCE / ILLUSTRATIVE

Lesson · solo setup

Invitations after setup

Reason · from the brief

The person may be starting alone.

Owner · product lead

Version 1, reviewed by the team

Review · after pilot / change

User test pending

DesignOps maintains the guidance.
The team checks it still applies.

# Faster is not the whole score.

EARLY EXPERIMENTATION · APPROXIMATE VALUES

## Brief → validated concept

| Baseline | Pilot | Change |
|---|---|---|
| 9d | 6d | −3 d |

median elapsed days

## Design production rate

| Baseline | Pilot | Change |
|---|---|---|
| ~3—4/wk | ~1—2/wk | ≈−2/wk |

accepted artifacts / in a team with 8w E2E Cycle

Change: midpoint estimate

## Review effort

| Baseline | Pilot | Change |
|---|---|---|
| 4h | 6h | +2 h |

person-hours / accepted concept

## Design-system compliance

| Baseline | Pilot | Change |
|---|---|---|
| 78% | 90% | +12 pp |

% applicable checks passed

**Review effort rises. Is the trade-off worth it?**

Compare equivalent work and verify user outcomes.

# One workflow.
# Thirty days. A measurable pilot.

DAYS 01—07

## Map

A map of AI use, gaps, and risk.

DAYS 08—14

## Select

One workflow with shared context.

DAYS 15—21

## Define

A review plan: owner, criteria, baseline.

DAYS 22—30

## Pilot

Comparable work, reviewed evidence.

THEN DECIDE **Adopt** / **Revise** / **Stop**

If AI becomes part of how we design products,

# who designs the system in which AI operates?

# DesignOps.

AI doesn't eliminate the need for DesignOps.
**It makes DesignOps infrastructure.**

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AI creates **capacity.**

Systems create **consistency.**

Stewardship creates **trust.**

DESIGNOPS AS AI INFRASTRUCTURE

# Let's talk.

Where is your team generating faster than it can maintain coherence?

LinkedIn · alvaradolj1 ↗

GitHub · JulianAlvarado ↗

01 Who owns governance? ↗

02 Do we become an AI team? ↗

03 What is an AI-ready design system? ↗

04 What happens when models change? ↗

05 How do we prove value? ↗

06 How does the context stack fit? ↗

07 Where does this fit in the lifecycle? ↗

↖ BACK TO Q&A

# Shared governance.
# Explicit decision rights.

BOUNDARIES

## Security + Legal

Data, privacy, risk, and policy.
Set non-negotiable constraints.

ACCESS

## IT + platform teams

Approved technology and access.
Maintain secure capabilities.

OPERATING MODEL

## DesignOps

Translate policy into workflows.
Facilitate context and evaluation.

PRODUCT JUDGMENT

## Domain experts

PM, research, design, engineering.
Own quality and release decisions.

Good governance pre-approves safe paths—not every individual click.

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# Architect the environment. Don't become the AI factory.

### Governance
Rules + risk

### Design intelligence
Consumable knowledge

### Workflow architecture
With domain experts

### Quality systems
Rubrics + evidence

### Enablement
Playbooks + training

### Measurement
Quality + outcomes

ENABLE DIFFERENT KINDS OF WORK

## Prototype → Build → Improve → Grow → Maintain

Exploration, production, simplification, experimentation, and reliability need different controls.

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# A component library with the reasoning attached.

## KEEP THE FOUNDATION

- Tokens
- Components
- Patterns
- Guidelines

+

## MAKE IT CONSUMABLE

- Semantic metadata
- Usage rules + constraints
- Examples + code equivalents
- Evaluation criteria

| SHARED CONTEXT | Owner | Version | Source | Freshness | Access |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|

Start with one pattern: its intent, code, valid uses, forbidden uses, and checks.

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# Models change.
# Your operating principles endure.

| KNOWLEDGE | RULES | WORKFLOWS | EVALUATION |
|---|---|---|---|

Model A ↔ Model B ↔ Model C

Re-run evaluation before switching.
Model-agnostic does not mean behavior-identical.

Canonical prompts encode domain knowledge—not one person's clever phrasing.

Co-author with PMs, researchers, designers, and engineers.
Version context, permissions, examples, and acceptance criteria together.

# Measure the workflow.
# Not the number of prompts.

Operational definitions for a scoped baseline and pilot

| Metric | Definition / unit | Collection method |
|---|---|---|
| Brief → validated concept | Median elapsed days; fixed validation criteria | Brief timestamp → review + user evidence |
| Design production rate | Accepted artifacts per team-week | Same artifact class, scope, and acceptance rubric |
| Production / review effort | Person-hours per accepted concept; report separately | Time log including critique + validation |
| Rework / revision rate | % reviewed artifacts requiring a major revision | Revision log; agree “major” before starting |
| System compliance | % applicable design-system checks passed | Token, component, and interaction-pattern audit |
| Accessibility / quality defects | Open defects per 10 reviewed screens + severity | Manual and automated checks, deduplicated |
| Design-to-code divergence | % audited UI instances violating approved intent | Paired design/code review of a defined sample |
| Experimentation / reuse | Completed experiments/week; % work citing approved context | Decision log; context provenance in artifacts |

Match scope + staffing. Record sample size + spread. Audit sampling bias. Track customer task success separately.
Small pilots are directional—not causal proof. Set adoption / revise / stop criteria before seeing results.

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# The advantage isn't the model. It's the memory.

What does your organization allow the model to know?

05 **DesignOps**
Connects the system · enables adoption

04 **Stewardship**
Guardrails · exclusions · human checkpoints

03 **Organizational context**
Tokens · components · research · brand · accessibility
Terminology · workflows · repos · product experiences

02 **Agents + tools**
Design assistants · coding agents · research tools

01 **Models**
Replaceable capabilities, not institutional knowledge

↖ BACK TO Q&A

# Same infrastructure.
# Every stage of the journey.

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 | 05 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| DISCOVER | DEFINE | DESIGN | BUILD | MEASURE |
| Synthesize research | Frame the problem | Explore concepts | Generate components | Interpret outcomes |

SHARED INFRASTRUCTURE — GOVERN — CONTEXT — EVALUATE